

May

SPECIAL EVENTS

PHASES OF THE MOON

	Full Moon	New Moon
2008	May 20	May 5
2009	May 9	May 24
2010	May 27	May 14
2011	May 17	May 3
2012	May 6	May 20

ECLIPSES

2012: May 20–21 An annular eclipse of the Sun is visible from the northern Pacific Ocean, southern Japan, and the western United States. A partial solar eclipse is seen from northeast Asia, the northern Pacific Ocean, and western North America.

THE PLANETS

2008: May 14 Mercury is at greatest evening elongation, magnitude 0.4.	2011: May 11 Venus and Jupiter appear about a Moon-width apart in the eastern dawn sky.
2010: May 26 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.5.	2011: May 21 Mercury and Mars appear about four Moon-widths apart in the eastern dawn sky.
2011: May 1 Mars and Jupiter appear about a Moon-width apart in the eastern dawn sky.	2011: May 23–24 Venus and Mars appear two Moon-widths apart in the eastern dawn sky.
2011: May 7 Mercury is at greatest morning elongation, magnitude 0.5.	
2011: May 7–20 Mercury and Venus appear three Moon-widths apart in the eastern dawn sky.	

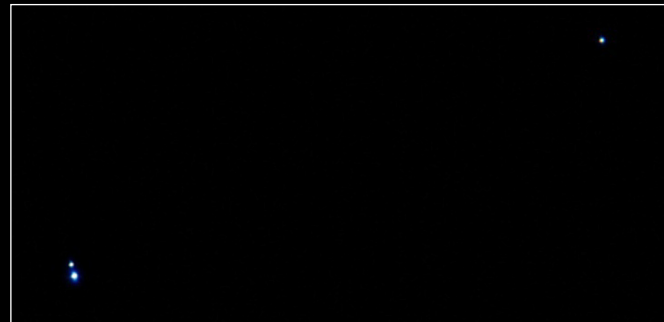
Elongation is explained on *page 14*

Boötes and Virgo are prominent for May observers in both the northern and southern hemispheres. Those to the south of the equator also see the constellations Crux and Centaurus, which are now at their highest above the horizon. In the northern hemisphere, the days are lengthening as summer approaches. Once the sky has darkened, Ursa Major stands high and proud in the northern sky.

NORTHERN LATITUDES

The bright star Spica and its constellation, Virgo, are due south. Higher in the sky, and almost overhead, is Arcturus in Boötes. The 13th “zodiac” constellation, Ophiuchus, is seen to the southeast. The head and body of Leo are still visible in the southwest, before sinking below the horizon. Antares, the red star that marks the heart of Scorpius, the scorpion, makes a rare appearance in the northern sky for those observers south of 50°N. It can be seen close to the horizon for the summer months.

Ursa Major is high in the sky to the north. The easily recognized shape of the Big Dipper is positioned so that the end of the handle is north and the bowl tips down to the west. Dubhe and Merak, the two brightest stars in Ursa Major, form the side of the bowl away from the handle. These are known as the pointers, since they point the way



Mizar and Alcor

This image shows the stars Mizar (left) and Alcor (right). They are usually seen as one star in the handle of the Big Dipper. When seen through a telescope (above), Mizar is found to have another companion.

to Polaris. Also known as the Pole Star, Polaris marks the position of the north celestial pole.

The summer stars Vega (in Lyra) and Deneb (in Cygnus) move higher into the northeastern sky as the last of the winter stars, Castor and Pollux (in Gemini), set in the northwest. Lyra is small but prominent due to its bright star Vega. It is also home to the planetary nebula, the Ring Nebula (M57), seen as a misty disk through a small telescope. The Eta Aquarid meteor shower (see opposite) is visible to observers in the lower latitudes.

